Conditionals: zero, first, second, third and mixed

Understand it

Conditionals connect a condition and a result. The type depends on how real the situation is. Zero: always true. First: real and possible in the future. Second: imagined or unlikely now. Third: an imagined past that did not happen. Mixed: past condition, present result.

In IELTS, conditionals are the grammar of solutions (If governments taxed sugar, people would eat less) and of Part 3 speculation (What would happen if ...?).

The rules

- Zero: if + present, present. If you heat ice, it melts. (always true)
- First: if + present, will + verb. If prices rise, people will buy less. (real future)
- Second: if + past simple, would + verb. If I had more time, I would travel. (imagined, unlikely)
- Third: if + past perfect, would have + past participle. If he had studied, he would have passed. (the past that did not happen). Mixed: If I had studied medicine, I would be a doctor now.

All the words and forms you need

Zero	If + present, present
First	If + present, will / can / may + verb
Second	If + past, would / could / might + verb (If I were ...)
Third	If + had + past participle, would have + past participle
Mixed	If + had + past participle, would + verb (now)
Other condition words	unless · provided that · as long as · in case · suppose / supposing · otherwise
Formal	Were the government to ..., Should you need ..., Had they known ...

Where you use it

Writing: Solutions: If governments invested in public transport, fewer people would drive.

Speaking: Part 3: What would happen if ...? If everyone worked from home, cities would be quieter.

Reading: Conditional sentences in a text often show a possibility, not a fact.

More examples

- If you heat water to 100 degrees, it boils.
- If we don't reduce plastic use, the oceans will suffer.
- If public transport were free, fewer people would drive.

- If cities had planned better, traffic would not be so bad today.
- Unless schools teach money skills, young people will get into debt.
- Provided that it is affordable, solar energy could replace coal.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ If I will have time, I will go.	✓ If I have time, I will go.
✗ If I would be rich, I would travel.	✓ If I were rich, I would travel.
✗ If he studied harder, he would have passed.	✓ If he had studied harder, he would have passed.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. What would you do if you won a lot of money?
2. If you could live in any country, where would you live?
3. What will you do if you get the score you need?
4. If you had studied something different, what would you be doing now?
5. What would happen if there were no cars in cities?

Writing practice

Write three solutions to traffic congestion, each as a second conditional sentence.

Practice

1. Complete (first): If it ___ (rain), we ___ (stay) home.

2. Complete (second): If I ___ (be) you, I ___ (take) the job.

3. Complete (third): If she ___ (leave) earlier, she ___ (catch) the train.

4. Correct: If people will recycle, waste will fall.

5. Correct: If I would know, I would tell you.

6. Mixed: If he ___ (study) law, he ___ (be) a lawyer now.

Answers

1. rains; will stay
2. were; would take
3. had left; would have caught
4. If people recycle, waste will fall.
5. If I knew, I would tell you.
6. had studied; would be